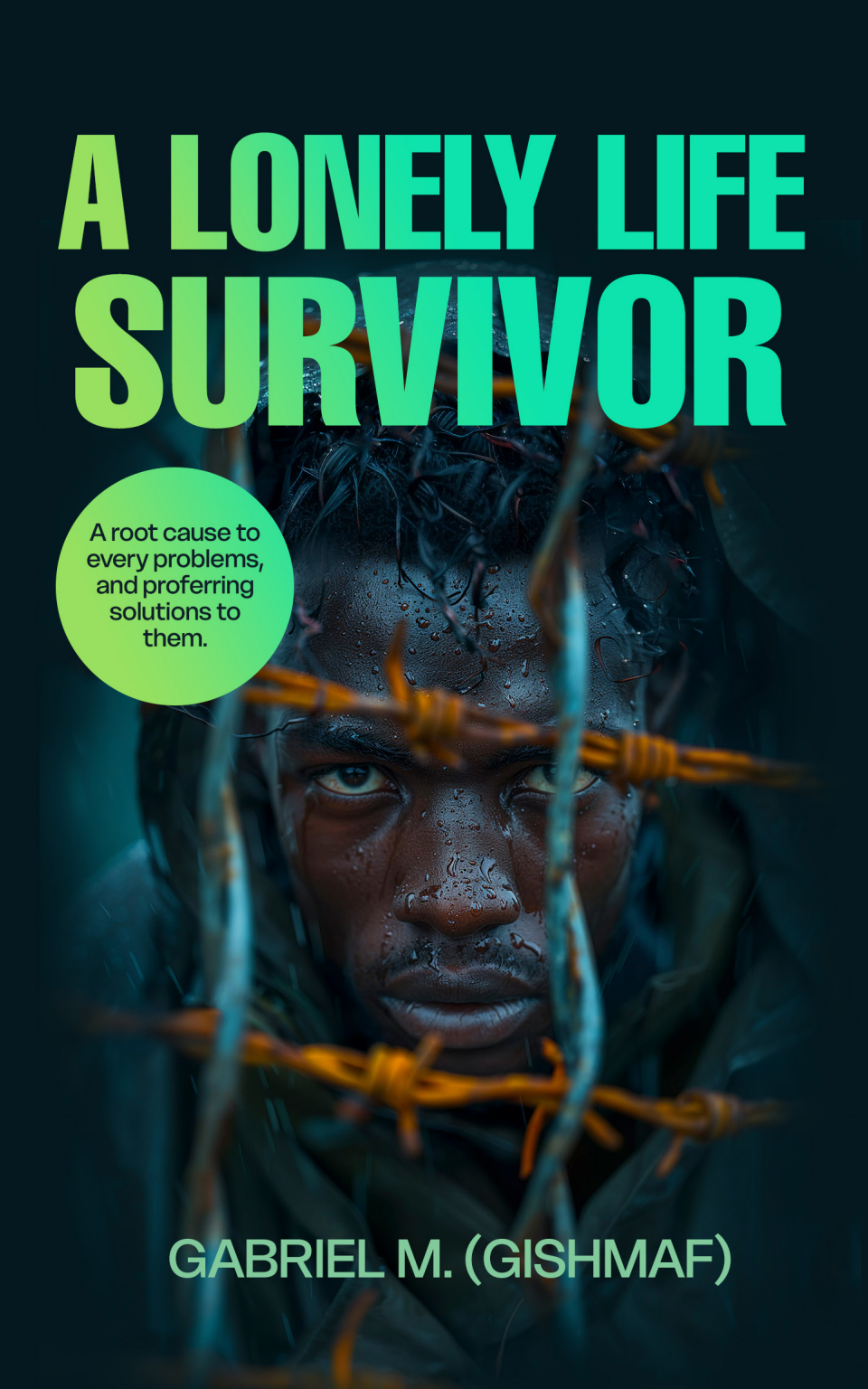


A LONELY LIFE SURVIVOR



A root cause to
every problems,
and proferring
solutions to
them.

GABRIEL M. (GISHMAF)

A
LONELY LIFE
SURVIVOR

GABRIEL M. (GISHMAF)

A Lonely Life Survivor

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Gabriel M. (Gishmaf)

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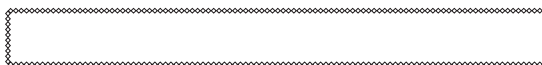


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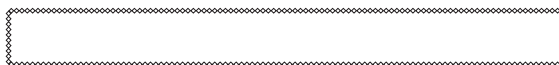




Introduction

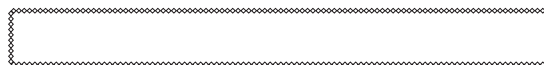


Alonely life is something no one would wish for or want to experience, as it is deeply challenging. Those who have endured loneliness and overcome it would never wish it upon anyone they care about. Many people today struggle to find balance in their lives, but often, their efforts fall short. In Africa, one of the root causes of such struggles is ignorance—specifically, a lack of understanding of basic life ethics



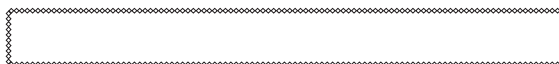
and principles. This ignorance manifests in various ways, particularly in family planning and parenting, leading to widespread societal issues.

A significant problem is the tendency of some parents to have more children than they can adequately provide for. This overpopulation, coupled with insufficient resources, contributes to poverty, suffering, and a rise in harmful behaviours such as robbery, cultism, and prostitution. When parents fail to meet their children's basic needs, they inadvertently place undue pressure on them. For instance, expecting a child between the ages of 7 and 17 to take full responsibility for their own well-being is



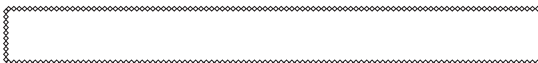
unrealistic and unfair. Such expectations leave children vulnerable to negative influences and harmful acts as they try to navigate life without proper guidance or support.

This issue of parental ignorance often stems from illiteracy—a lack of basic education that limits parents’ understanding of life ethics and living standards. Without access to knowledge, many parents are confined to narrow, outdated perspectives on family and responsibility. Historically, in many African communities, large families were seen as an asset. Parents had many children to help with farm work, and families were often judged by the number



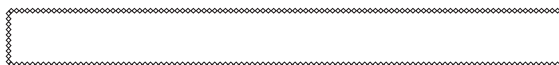
of children they had. Additionally, some parents hold onto the belief that they must continue having children until they produce a male heir, especially in cases where previous children are female. This mindset is driven by the desire to preserve their bloodline and honour their ancestors.

However, this narrow-minded approach often leads to severe financial strain. Many parents operate under the assumption that each child will “find their way” in life, but this is neither realistic nor fair. Children need proper support, guidance, and resources to thrive. Every responsible parent should consider their children’s future and ensure they can



provide for their basic needs, including education, healthcare, and emotional support. Parents can set their children up for successful growth and development, breaking the cycle of poverty and ignorance by doing so.

Addressing parental ignorance and promoting education are essential steps toward improving living standards and reducing societal problems. Parents must be encouraged to plan their families responsibly, considering their financial capabilities and their children's future. Only then can we create a society where children are given the tools they need to succeed, rather than being left to navigate life's challenges alone.



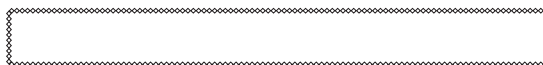


WHAT IS A LONELY LIFE?



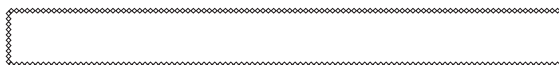


A lonely life is one where you must live and survive without external help or support. In such a life, you are entirely responsible for yourself, with no one to lean on, ask for advice, share ideas, or build meaningful relationships. This kind of existence is incredibly challenging and often affects individuals who are poor, orphaned, abandoned, or struggling to find their place in the world. For example, imagine the difficulty of a child trying to



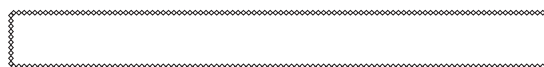
navigate school life without any support from parents or siblings. Such a situation leaves them vulnerable to negative thoughts and emotions, including self-doubt, depression, and even self-harm. It takes immense mental discipline, often coupled with faith, to resist these harmful pressures.

The lack of support and guidance can lead vulnerable individuals down dangerous paths. A girl in this situation, for instance, may be tempted to turn to prostitution due to persistent pressure from wealthy men, peer influence, or sheer desperation caused by hardship. Similarly, a boy in such circumstances might be drawn to join a secret cult,



believing it offers a way to gain power, resources, or a sense of belonging. These choices often stem from a lack of alternatives and the overwhelming need to survive in a world that has left them to fend for themselves.

In both cases, the absence of a support system increases the risk of falling into destructive behaviours. Without guidance, encouragement, or a sense of stability, individuals in these situations are more likely to make decisions that harm themselves or others. Addressing these challenges requires not only personal resilience but also societal intervention to provide support, opportunities, and hope for those living in isolation and vulnerability.



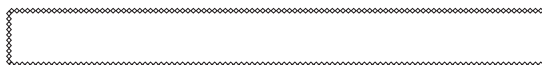


WHAT DOES LIVING A LONELY LIFE MEAN?



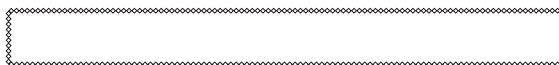


Living with loneliness is a complex and often ambiguous experience, especially if you've gone through it yourself. I remember my first time traveling abroad to a country where I knew no one. My only connections were a few friends I had met on social media. I was eager to learn what to expect in this new place, but the journey was challenging. My desperation to leave my home country was fuelled by the perceptions I had built



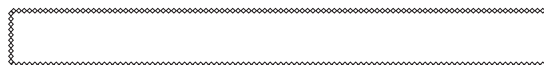
up, but the reality of being alone in a foreign land was far more daunting than I had imagined.

This experience, along with other life lessons, taught me what it truly means to live and survive without a support system. It's a harsh reality that many people face, and we shouldn't ignore it. Life is complicated, filled with lessons that often come through personal experiences or encounters with others. Imagine the frustration of making avoidable mistakes simply because there's no one to guide your thoughts, correct your errors, or offer advice. This is the reality for many individuals—students struggling to choose the right course of study, learners



without tutors to help them overcome academic challenges, those in need of financial support, and people at critical decision-making points in their lives.

To anyone in this situation, I encourage you to stay strong and keep pushing forward until things improve. And to those who have the support they need; I urge you to use your privilege to positively impact others. We all rely on each other to navigate life's challenges, and by lifting others up, we create a more compassionate and connected world.





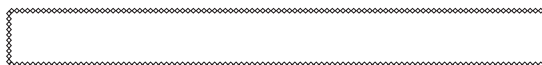
THE MYSTERY OF LIFE





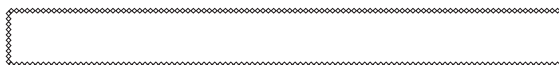
Life is an incredibly complex and mysterious subject. Despite our best efforts, many events occur that we cannot fully explain. As the saying goes, life is a journey, and each individual follows a path shaped by their choices. You decide what to do, when to do it, and which direction to take. Ultimately, your path is determined by the choices you make.

Even with all the advancements in science, fundamental questions about



life remain unanswered. Scientists have explored the intricacies of organisms, but they still struggle to define what life truly is or where it originates. Have you ever wondered what makes something alive? What is that intangible quality that vanishes the moment a living being dies? Consider a baby who has just passed away: its body contains the same DNA, heart, and mass as it did moments before, yet something essential is now missing.

Interestingly, there is no universal agreement on the definition of life. Wikipedia acknowledges, “There is no universal definition of life; various definitions have been proposed by different scientists.” Similarly, the



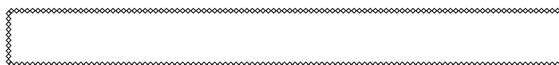
Encyclopaedia Britannica states, “There is no generally accepted definition of life.” Its online version attempts a definition filled with complex scientific jargon, but even this falls short of capturing the essence of life. This ongoing mystery highlights how much we still have to learn about the nature of existence itself.

A biochemical or molecular definition describes living organisms as systems that contain hereditary information encoded in nucleic acids and regulate chemical reactions using protein-based enzymes. However, such definitions don’t truly explain what life is—they only describe observable characteristics of living things. Biologist and philosopher Harold J. Morowitz notes that all known

life shares one common feature: it is cellular. As he puts it, “The only life we know for certain is cellular.”

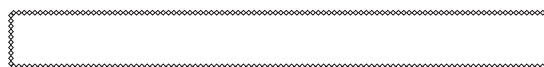
British educational guidelines for students aged 11 to 14 suggest that life can be identified by seven qualities, summarized by the mnemonic MRS. GREN: Movement, Respiration, Sensitivity, Growth, Reproduction, Excretion, and Nutrition. While these traits are typical of cellular life, they still fail to define the essence of life itself.

To better grasp the challenge of defining life, consider comparing a cell to a powerful computer. A computer is a highly complex system that stores and processes information, but it requires a



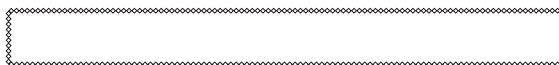
designer, programmer, engineer, power source, and operator to function. Despite its sophistication, a computer is not alive. For example, if a computer shuts down, it can be rebooted, but a living organism, like a housefly, cannot simply be “restarted” once it dies. This distinction highlights the profound gap between even the most advanced technology and the complexity of life.

Interestingly, the Bible does not provide a definition of life, but it distinguishes between animals and plants. It refers to plants as “green things” (Job 39:8), implying a different order of existence compared to animals. Most scientists agree that plant life operates



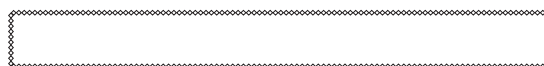
on a different level than animal life. For instance, seeing a dead tree in a forest might not disturb us—we might even sit on its stump. In contrast, most people would avoid sitting on a dead animal. Similarly, while we might display dead flowers in a vase, few would consider doing the same with a dead mouse. These observations underscore the unique and mysterious nature of life, which continues to elude simple definition.

The Bible marvels at the wonders of life but never provides a strict definition of it. On the fifth day of creation, God introduced this extraordinary phenomenon: “And God said, Let the waters bring forth abundantly the moving



creature that hath life” (Genesis 1:20 KJV). The Hebrew word used here for life is *nephesh*, which refers to a living being or soul. Leviticus 17:11 further connects life to blood, stating, “For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it to you upon the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement for the soul.” While this verse links life to blood, it still doesn’t define what life truly is.

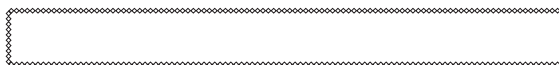
The life described in the Bible transcends the physical. Although life produces observable physical effects, its essence is intangible—a force granted by God’s command. Despite scientific advancements in understanding the



physical systems of organisms and their origins, the deeper question of where life itself comes from remains unanswered. Even if you could assemble a baby with all its physical components perfectly in place, it would still lack the spark of life. According to the Bible, life is a divine gift from God, bestowed or withdrawn by His will, not by physical processes.

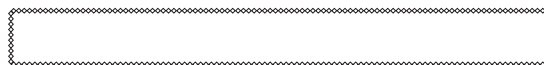
Though we may not fully understand what life is, we can observe it all around us. Its presence points to the Life-Giver, who makes all life possible. God uses the mysteries of His creation to reveal Himself to humanity.

In fact, human life holds a higher significance than the life of animals. After



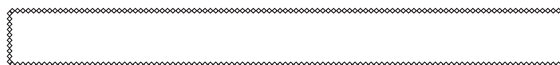
Adam and Eve's rebellion, humanity lost its right to this elevated form of life. While our bodies may appear vibrant and full of energy, the Bible describes humanity as spiritually dead. The world, in this sense, is like a spiritual graveyard, filled with individuals who may seem alive but lack the deeper, more profound quality of life that comes from a relationship with the Creator. As Jesus declared, "I am the life" (John 14:6), emphasizing that true life extends far beyond mere physical existence.

Jesus Christ, the Life-Giver, entered our world to restore what was lost—everlasting life. This life, offered by the Creator, is available to all but can only



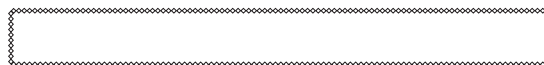
be found in one place: “He who has the Son has life; he who does not have the Son of God does not have life” (1 John 5:12). God holds the power to grant this life, and He invites us to place our faith in Him, trusting in the sacrifice of His Son, who paid the price for our sins so that we might receive eternal life. As the Bible states, “He who believes in the Son has everlasting life, and he who does not believe the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God abides on him” (John 3:36).

Articles in spirituality sections often explore topics based on widely held beliefs about phenomena that exist beyond our current scientific understanding. While the exact details of these phenomena

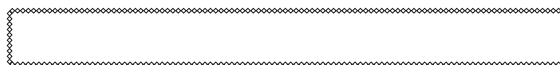


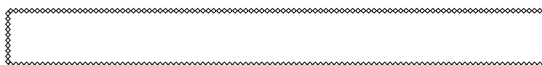
remain largely unknown or shrouded in mystery, they invite us to approach fringe topics in alternative sciences with cautious optimism. The universe is vast and largely unexplored, constantly surprising us with new realities. By asking the right questions and exploring unconventional possibilities, we may uncover answers that deepen our understanding of existence.

This sense of wonder is deeply ingrained in our instincts, driving us to seek fulfilment and meaning. Research into the lives and trials of our ancestors reveals how their experiences laid the foundation for the world we live in today. Yet, despite this knowledge, we



instinctively sense that there is more to our existence than what we currently understand. Many of us feel that our time on Earth is just a fleeting moment in a larger, extraordinary spiritual journey with a profound purpose. While this realization is universal—whether conscious or not—few know how to act on it. The demands of daily life—obligations, relationships, and ambitions—often push these deeper questions to the back of our minds, leaving them unresolved. Nevertheless, the search for meaning and connection to something greater remains an integral part of the human experience.





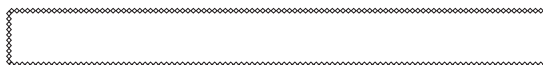


THE QUEST FOR SURVIVAL



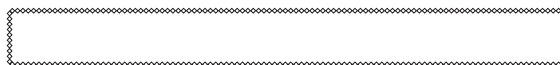


The struggle for survival varies greatly among individuals, often leading many to encounter situations that unknowingly shorten their lifespans. For instance, consider a teenage girl raised by a single mother but left to fend for herself. In today's society, such a girl faces numerous challenges, including vulnerability to sexual assault, feelings of inferiority among peers, stunted personal growth, and a lack of understanding of social norms early in life.

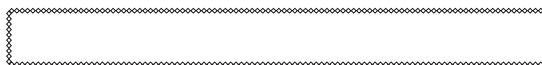


Often, individuals in such circumstances learn through trial and error, but the consequences of their mistakes can accumulate over time. Many lonely survivors face higher mortality rates due to the long-term effects of poor decisions made during their teenage and young adult years. These may include engaging in risky sexual behaviors, experimenting with harmful drugs, developing dangerous smoking habits, or other detrimental activities. Some enter these habits knowingly, while others stumble into them unknowingly, only to become addicted later.

A few years ago, I had a friend from Pakistan who worked with me in an

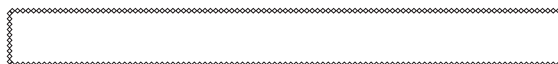


industrial setting. He was employed in the steel factory, a particularly grueling section due to the intense heat, loud machinery, and exposure to hazardous chemicals. The company lacked a safety culture, as management prioritized profits over employee well-being and avoided implementing safety measures to cut costs. My friend had been brought to the company by an agent and was required to repay a debt before gaining his independence. Despite the dangerous working conditions, he had no choice but to continue working without proper safety precautions, as the company neglected even the most basic health and safety standards.



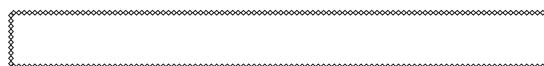
After years of working in unsafe conditions at the company, my friend developed severe heart and muscle pain. Eventually, the company dismissed him and a few others whose efficiency had declined due to health issues. This highlights a broader issue: many individuals who endure harsh lives in their youth often face negative consequences later, such as premature death or life-threatening illnesses resulting from their earlier struggles.

How can we address this problem in today's world? Society and individuals alike must recognize the importance of health and safety. People should be mindful of the long-term effects of their



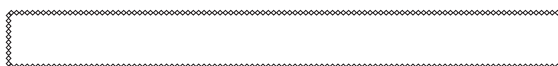
actions and prioritize their well-being with utmost seriousness. As the saying goes, “To live is one, and to die is also one.” Keeping this in mind can encourage individuals to take proactive steps to protect themselves before engaging in harmful practices or environments.

In the quest for survival, many fall into spiritual or emotional indebtedness. Some knowingly take on burdens due to anxiety or a desperate drive for success, while others are deceived into such situations by friends or societal pressures. Breaking free from these entanglements can be difficult, as they often involve complex spiritual or psychological forces. To avoid such pitfalls, individuals

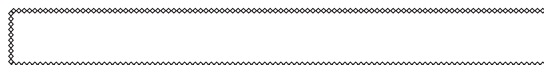


must exercise caution in all endeavors, considering both physical and spiritual safety. This holistic approach can help prevent future harm and ensure a more secure path forward.

The journey for survival yields varied outcomes. Some individuals rise from humble beginnings to achieve significant success, transforming their lives entirely. Others, however, are less fortunate and may not survive the challenges they face. The reasons behind these differing outcomes remain complex and deeply rooted, often requiring careful analysis to understand. Life is a precious gift, a truth emphasized in religious texts like the Bible, and should be valued



and protected. In today's world, where both good and bad events unfold simultaneously, it is essential to remain vigilant and intentional in safeguarding one's well-being.



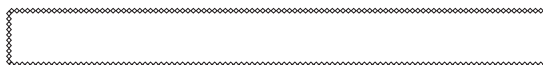


SURVIVING POVERTY WITH NO HELP IN SIGHT



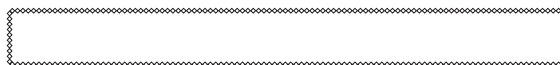


Success is a universal aspiration, deeply rooted in the mind and shaped by one's perception, mindset, and vision. It is the outcome or result of an endeavour, whether positive or negative, and its meaning varies depending on individual goals and levels of contentment. Importantly, success can manifest in different areas, some of which may involve harmful or unethical actions. Therefore, the path one chooses to achieve success is as significant as

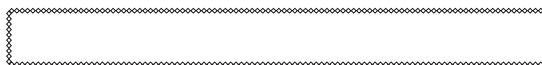


the success itself. In this book, however, the focus will be on positive success—achievements that align with constructive and ethical pursuits.

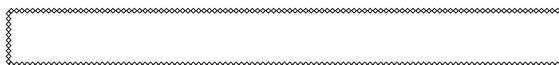
Living a lonely life while striving for success can be incredibly challenging and, without decisive action, may even seem unattainable. However, it is achievable. In a world where both positive and negative events unfold simultaneously, individuals must carefully guard their hearts and minds against harmful influences. Even small missteps can derail the path to success, making it essential to remain focused and intentional throughout the journey.



Imagine a young man, aware of his lonely and struggling circumstances, striving for success by pursuing higher education to improve his opportunities. Despite his efforts, he ends up getting a girl pregnant—a girl who is also unemployed and still in school. With no home of his own and squatting with a friend, his situation becomes even more challenging. Now, consider a young woman who becomes pregnant, either due to assault or by conforming to a relationship with a wealthy man who can provide for her immediate needs. These scenarios highlight the added difficulties faced by individuals striving for success while navigating life's complexities.

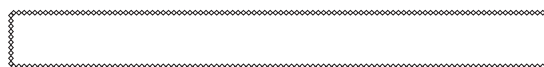


Research shows that lonely individuals often take longer to achieve success compared to those with support systems. I often question claims of people reaching the top at a young age without any help from family or others, as such stories seem unrealistic. According to natural laws, something must propel an individual forward—whether it's a natural force, external support, or even supernatural intervention. For instance, a close friend once told me about a man who claimed to have become wealthy in Lagos entirely on his own, without any help from family or siblings. Skeptical, I asked questions: Who brought him to Lagos? Where did he stay when he arrived? What was he doing before



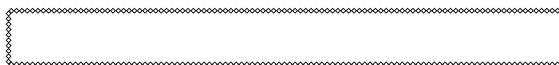
coming to Lagos? How did he accumulate his wealth? It turned out that his uncle, a well-known businessman, brought him to Lagos, provided for his basic needs, and connected him to a famous comedian who employed him as an assistant. Over time, he saved enough money to build his career and achieve success. This story underscores the reality that most individuals who succeed quickly often have some form of support, even if it's not immediately visible.

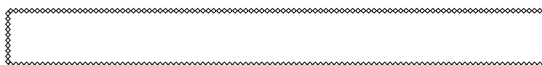
While some may achieve success through negative means, such paths often come with consequences. However, it doesn't change the fact that external forces—whether positive or negative—



play a role in propelling individuals toward their goals. Life is inherently interconnected, and we are meant to support one another in achieving our aims, much like how women complement men in various aspects of life.

One truth to remember is that every effort or motion faces opposing forces. These can be natural obstacles or human-made challenges, such as greed, jealousy, laziness, or cruelty. These contrasting forces can hinder progress, making it essential to recognize and navigate them wisely on the journey to success.





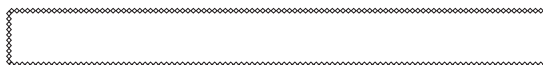


SURVIVING AS A LONELY ELDER AND HOW TO PLAN FOR THE FUTURE



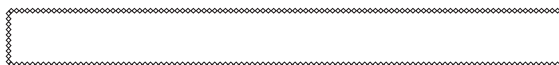


We all aspire to live our later years in a comfortable and secure place we can call our own, valuing our independence as much as our personal space. However, our emphasis on self-reliance often leads us to believe we can manage everything alone. As more Americans choose to live single, childless lives to focus on careers and personal goals, the question, “How will I take care of myself as I age?” becomes unavoidable.



Aging brings inevitable changes to our physical and mental capabilities, raising concerns about how to navigate the challenges of immobility and dependence. Can willpower alone suffice to combat the risks of aging? How can one achieve the retirement they envisioned without a support system?

The number of baby boomers aging alone is steadily rising. Geriatric experts refer to them as “elder orphans”—individuals without adult children, a spouse, relatives, or other support networks to rely on for assistance and companionship in their senior years. A doctor friend noted that the population of “lonely elders” grows annually as



more baby boomers retire. This trend is concerning, as the majority of care for older adults is typically provided by family. My research revealed that 22 percent of Nigerians aged 65 and older are also aging alone, lacking family or support systems to care for them, with women making up the majority of this group. This highlights a growing global challenge: the need to address the vulnerabilities of those aging without a support network.

Who is an “Elder Orphan”?

An “elder orphan” refers to an older adult who ages alone, often without the support of family, friends, or a social network. These individuals

face significant challenges, including isolation, difficulty performing daily tasks, and increased risks of cognitive decline, cardiovascular diseases, and premature death. To illustrate this, consider the case of Mr. Oguntade, a 76-year-old man from Ogun State, Nigeria, whom I met during a hospital visit. Mr. Oguntade was hospitalized for multiple health issues, including dehydration, malnutrition, bedsores, depression, and self-inflicted cuts on his wrists. For years, he had lived in complete isolation, with no contact from relatives for over a year. Unable to provide the long-term care he needed, the hospital transferred him to a nursing home, where he would likely spend the remainder of his life.

Who is at Greater Risk of Becoming an “Elder Orphan”?

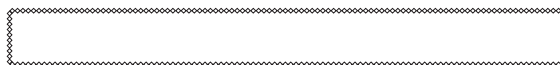
Research and studies on “elder orphans” suggest that anyone can become one, but certain groups are at higher risk. These include:

- ★ Older adults who live in isolation.
- ★ Older adults estranged from siblings or family.
- ★ Single older adults without children.
- ★ Single older adults with estranged children.
- ★ Childless married couples with estranged children.

- ★ Single older adults with no or limited social circles or support groups.
- ★ Older women without support systems.

In essence, neither having children nor being married guarantees protection from becoming an “elder orphan.” What matters most is how we cultivate and maintain relationships with people who can serve as reliable support systems in our later years. Building strong social ties is crucial to ensuring we are not left vulnerable and alone as we age.

Carney emphasizes, “We are all at risk of becoming isolated and turning into elder orphans.” Even if you’re

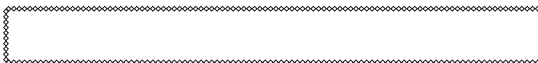


married, you might outlive your spouse. Even if you have children, they may be too busy or unable to care for you due to their own life commitments. “Everyone must prepare to live as independently as possible,” Carney advises.

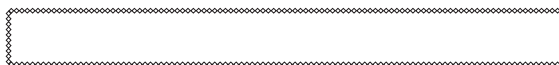
Common Issues and Concerns of “Elder Orphans”

Unlike older adults with strong support systems, “elder orphans” face unique vulnerabilities, including:

1. **Loneliness:** Aging alone often leads to profound loneliness, which can diminish the ability to perform daily tasks, increase the risk of cognitive illnesses and cardiovascular diseases, and raise mortality rates.



2. **Social Isolation:** Older adults who age alone and avoid social interactions are more likely to experience medical complications, depression, and reduced mobility. They also lack immediate support to address their needs or handle emergencies.
3. **Abuse:** Elder orphans are at higher risk of physical, emotional, and financial abuse. Without family to protect them, they may fall victim to exploitation, theft, or manipulation by those who take advantage of their isolation and vulnerability.
4. **Lack of Legal and Financial Support:** While some older adults rely on their children to manage legal and



financial matters, elder orphans often lack such mechanisms. This leaves them exposed to potential fraud or mismanagement, especially as their cognitive abilities decline.

How to Plan for the Stages of Aging as an “Elder Orphan”

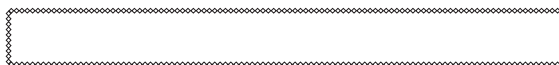
Mrs. Amaka, an aging expert and self-identified “elder orphan,” has documented her experiences of living alone in her online articles. In one of her pieces, “Baby Boomers Aging Alone Plan,” she highlights the importance of understanding the stages of aging as the first step in preparing for life as an elder orphan. By planning ahead, individuals

can better navigate the challenges of aging independently.

For those approaching their later years, understanding the stages of aging can help you plan effectively for a future lived independently. Here's a breakdown of the stages to consider:

First Stage: Independence

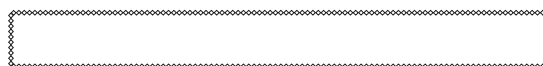
In this stage, you are generally self-sufficient and capable of managing minor health issues, chronic conditions, or disabilities. You can rely on your own abilities and do not yet require assistance from others. This is the ideal time to evaluate your living situation and community to determine if they will



provide the support you need as you age. Focus on maintaining your health and planning for potential future care needs. Consider where you want to live long-term—whether in your own home, an assisted living facility, or an affordable nursing home. Plan your finances carefully to cover future expenses, and prepare essential documents such as a will or power of attorney. Additionally, explore ways to advocate for yourself and build a network of support.

Second Stage: Interdependence

As you enter this stage, you may need help with basic tasks like cleaning, household chores, and other routine activities. For elder orphans,



this phase can be challenging, but there are growing options as more baby boomers face similar situations. Consider hiring caregivers or domestic helpers for assistance. Alternatively, explore group homes, communes, or independent living facilities that offer security, clean accommodations, meals, laundry, and cleaning services. Building interdependence, even without family support, is crucial during this stage.

Third Stage: Dependence

In this stage, you may require help with essential daily activities such as dressing, bathing, meal preparation, grooming, driving, shopping, and even walking. At this point, continuing-

care retirement communities can be an excellent option. These facilities provide various levels of care tailored to individuals' needs, ensuring support through all stages of aging. Planning ahead for this stage ensures you have the necessary resources and arrangements in place to maintain your quality of life.

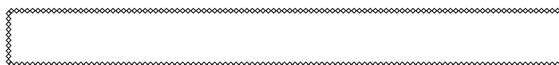
Fourth Stage: High Dependency

This stage involves a greater need for medical care, as you may become heavily reliant on health professionals and medical institutions to meet your medical needs. For older adults with chronic conditions or a family history of age-related illnesses, it's crucial to plan for potential health crises well in advance.

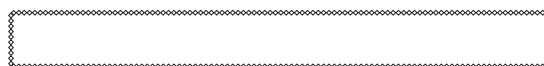
Financial preparation is especially important if you live alone, as cognitive impairments or severe health issues may leave you unable to make decisions for yourself when a crisis arises.

Fifth Stage: End-of-Life Care

This final stage requires extensive medical and personal care, often provided in a nursing home or hospice. Before reaching this point, it's essential to prepare a Durable Medical Power of Attorney. This legal document designates a trusted person to make medical decisions on your behalf if you become unable to communicate or understand your situation. The appointed individual will oversee your medical care, including



decisions about tests, medications, hydration, nourishment, doctors, hospitals, surgeries, and rehabilitation facilities. Preparing this in advance ensures your wishes are respected and proper care is provided during this critical stage.



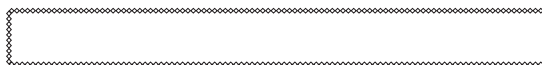


PREPARATION FOR OLD AGE WITH NO SPOUSE, KIDS OR CAREGIVERS





According to Miss Kofoworola, a nurse and caregiver from Ekiti State, older adults who feel lonely are more likely to struggle with daily tasks, experience cognitive decline, develop coronary heart disease, and even face a higher risk of premature death. Socially isolated individuals are also vulnerable to medical complications, mental illness, mobility issues, and difficulties accessing healthcare. Miss Kofoworola emphasizes,



“You could be in a hospital during a crisis and face delays in treatment or care, and your wishes may not be respected if you can’t communicate them.”

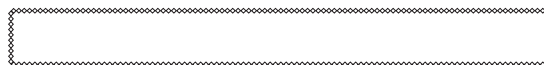
A 2012 study of over 2,100 adults aged 50 and older found that the loneliest individuals were nearly twice as likely to die within six years compared to the least lonely, regardless of their health behaviors or social status. Social connections can also help prevent depression, which affects nearly 20% of people aged 65 and older, according to the National Alliance on Mental Illness. As Mr. Paul notes, “One of the things that keeps people from being depressed is being connected. The more social activities you have, the

more friends, the more things you can do to keep your body and mind active—that’s the best protection against mental illness.”

PRACTICAL STEPS FOR AGING WELL:

1. Appoint a Proxy:

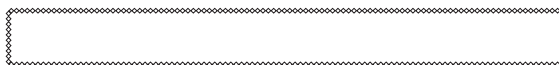
Identify a trusted friend or relative to assist you in times of crisis. Ensure they know essential details, such as where you keep your insurance card, the medications you take, and other critical information. Periodically revisit this choice as your circumstances change. If you’re unable to make decisions, designate this person as your durable power of attorney for



healthcare. If no one comes to mind, consider hiring an attorney specializing in elder care law. These professionals are licensed, experienced, and can provide reliable support.

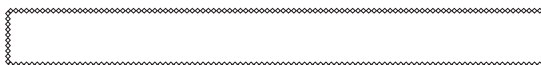
2. Consider Moving:

Think about relocating to a more walkable community, such as a college town, where you can stay engaged with activities like mentoring and be surrounded by both young people and like-minded older adults. A supportive community can provide companionship and mutual care.



3. Live Well:

Prioritize your health by eating nutritious foods and staying physically active. Poor diet and lack of exercise are major contributors to chronic conditions. Additionally, keep your mind sharp to make informed decisions about your healthcare and overall well-being.



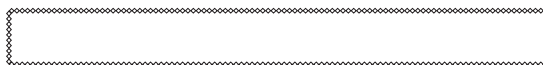


SURVIVING AS A SINGLE PARENT



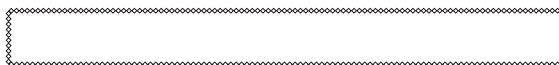


Raising a child as a single parent presents unique challenges, often accompanied by increased pressure, stress, and fatigue. Without a partner to share responsibilities, the demands of day-to-day childcare fall solely on you. This can lead to emotional exhaustion, making it harder to provide consistent emotional support or discipline, which may contribute to behavioral issues in your child. Additionally, single-parent



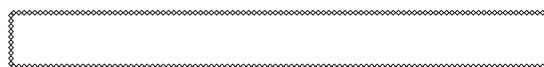
families often face financial strain, with lower incomes and limited access to healthcare. Balancing work and childcare can be both financially taxing and socially isolating. Concerns about the absence of a male or female role model for your child may also arise.

To mitigate these challenges, adopting positive strategies can help reduce stress and create a supportive environment for your child. Start by expressing love and appreciation—praise your child regularly and offer unconditional support. Dedicate time each day to connect through play, reading, or simply sitting together. Establishing a routine with structured activities, such as regular meal and



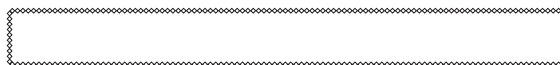
bedtime schedules, provides stability and helps your child know what to expect. When childcare is needed, prioritize finding a qualified caregiver who offers a safe and stimulating environment. Avoid relying solely on an older child for babysitting, and be cautious about entrusting a new friend or partner with childcare responsibilities.

Setting clear boundaries is equally important. Communicate house rules and expectations, such as respectful communication, and enforce them consistently. Collaborate with other caregivers in your child's life to ensure unified discipline. Periodically reassess limits, such as screen time, as your



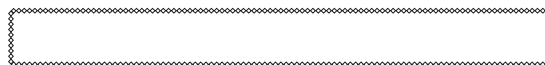
child matures and demonstrates readiness for more responsibility. Avoid guilt-driven parenting—refrain from overcompensating for single parenthood by spoiling your child or blaming yourself. Instead, prioritize self-care by incorporating physical activity, maintaining a healthy diet, and ensuring adequate sleep. Schedule regular breaks by arranging childcare, even if only for a few hours a week, to recharge and engage in activities you enjoy.

Building a support network is crucial. Coordinate with other parents for carpooling, join single-parent support groups, or seek assistance from social services. Lean on friends, family, and

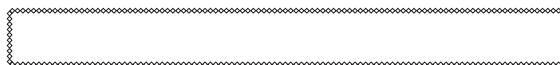


neighbors for help, and consider faith communities as additional resources. Maintaining a positive outlook is key—be honest with your child about challenges, but reassure them that things will improve. Encourage age-appropriate responsibilities without expecting them to act like “little adults,” and approach everyday challenges with humor. Be mindful that teens in single-parent households may face higher risks of depression and lower self-esteem. Watch for signs such as social isolation, sadness, irritability, or hopelessness, and consult a doctor if these symptoms arise.

For families formed after divorce or separation, open communication is



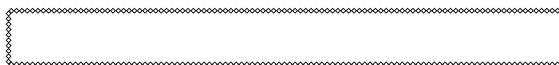
essential. Discuss the changes with your child, listen to their feelings, and answer their questions honestly without criticizing the other parent. Reassure your child that the separation was not their fault and that your love for them remains unwavering. A counselor can help facilitate conversations about fears or concerns. Maintain regular communication with your child's other parent to prioritize their well-being and ensure a smooth adjustment. Research shows that children cope best with divorce when parents collaborate on co-parenting, placing their child's needs above personal conflicts.

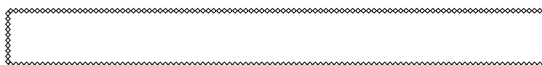


If you're dating, consider how a new romantic partner may affect your child. Choose someone who respects both you and your child, and wait until the relationship is stable before introducing them. When the time comes, highlight your partner's positive qualities to your child, but allow their relationship to develop naturally. Clarify that the new partner is not replacing the other parent. If your child lacks a male or female role model, seek opportunities to highlight positive examples of the opposite sex within your family, community, or media. Challenge negative stereotypes and foster relationships with responsible individuals who can serve as role models. Demonstrate that healthy, long-term

relationships with the opposite sex are possible.

While single parenting is undeniably challenging, it can also be deeply rewarding. By offering love, respect, and honest communication, you can reduce stress and create an environment where your child can thrive. Staying positive and proactive will help you navigate the complexities of single parenthood while fostering your child's growth and well-being.





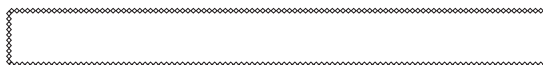


SURVIVING AS A PREGNANT WOMAN





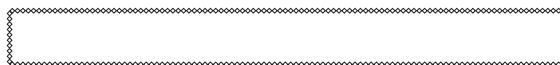
Many women find themselves navigating single motherhood after their partners leave during or after a pregnancy. Some are left by husbands or boyfriends who initially seemed committed but walked away upon learning about the pregnancy or realizing the demands of raising a child. Others become pregnant knowing they might have to raise the child alone. According to personal research, more than 40% of



children in South Africa and Nigeria—approximately 9 million children—live with only their mothers. While this reality may feel overwhelming, it's important to remember that you are not alone. As you face the future with this significant responsibility, two things can make a world of difference: support and knowledge.

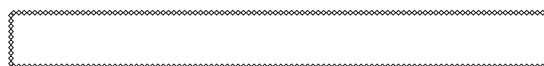
Emotional Support

The emotional toll of single motherhood often begins with grieving the loss of a relationship, the dream of a shared family life, or the expectation of having a partner on the journey of parenthood. If your partner has already expressed disinterest in the baby, at least you know



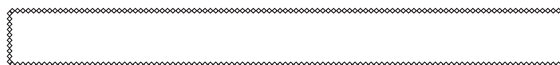
where you stand. However, many single mothers experience a double grief: mourning the end of their relationship and the disappointment of their child being abandoned by their father.

It's natural to worry about how the stress of a broken relationship might affect your bond with your unborn child. Acknowledge these feelings of disappointment and anxiety—they are valid. By understanding and addressing these emotions, you can prevent them from overshadowing your pregnancy and allow yourself to see your baby as an individual deserving of love and care. Take moments to breathe, speak kindly to yourself, and recognize the strength



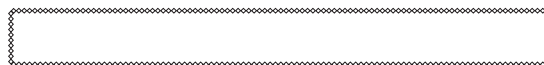
it takes to navigate this challenging situation.

If you find yourself clinically depressed or struggling to cope, seek professional help immediately. Reach out to a doctor, clinic nurse, social worker, or psychologist. Some partners leave out of fear or immaturity, unable to handle the responsibilities of fatherhood. In such cases, there's a chance they may eventually want to be involved in their child's life or even reconcile with you—if that's what you want. However, if the relationship was abusive—whether emotionally or physically—it's not worth salvaging, even during pregnancy.



Instead, focus on whether your ex can be a reliable father to your child. Ask yourself: Can he commit to this role long-term? If the answer is no, it's best to let go and move forward. As my mother, Mrs. Virginia Mafiana, wisely says, "A first pregnancy can be new and scary, but a support group can help normalize your experience."

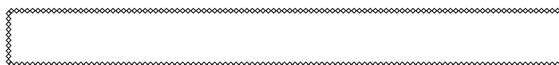
Facing the end of a relationship while preparing for motherhood is an enormous challenge. Lean on your support system—whether it's your mother, aunt, friend, colleague, or online pregnancy groups. You may be romantically unattached, but you don't have to face this journey alone.



Financial Support

If you're unexpectedly pregnant and single, financial concerns are likely at the forefront of your mind. How will you afford to raise a child on a single income? In many cases, you can seek financial support from the child's father, whether or not you were married. This may include child maintenance, help with pregnancy-related expenses, or contributions to medical bills. Fathers have a legal and moral obligation to support their children until they are independent, and mothers also play a crucial role in providing for their child.

For unmarried parents, a parenting agreement can clarify roles and



expectations, such as visitation schedules and financial contributions. However, if your ex-partner is unemployed or unable to contribute, you may need to budget carefully and rely solely on your income.

Practical Support

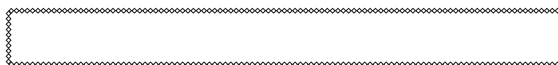
As the sole provider, it's essential to plan early for childcare. If you don't live with family, consider trusted relatives, daycare centers, or even shared living arrangements with other single parents. Sharing responsibilities like transportation, cooking, cleaning, and babysitting can ease the burden.

Birth Support

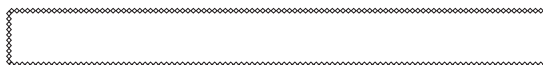
Think about who will accompany you during labor and delivery. You don't want to go to the hospital alone, so choose someone you trust to be there for you. Attend antenatal classes with your chosen birth partner to ensure they're prepared to support you during this critical time.

Building Your Support Structure

Whether by choice or circumstance, building a strong support network during pregnancy is crucial. Surround yourself with people who can offer emotional, financial, and practical help. Single motherhood is a challenging journey, but



with the right support and resources, you can navigate it successfully and provide a loving environment for your child.



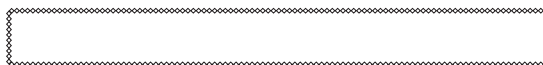


SURVIVING AS A YOUNG MARRIED MAN PROVIDING FOR THE FAMILY



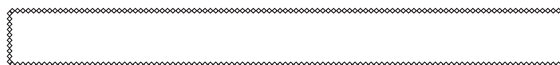


Unlike many women, who often turn to close friends for comfort or advice, most men tend to handle their problems differently. When something bothers them, men are more likely to retreat and process their emotions internally, seeking logical solutions on their own. They prefer to mull things over in solitude before deciding on their next steps. What often goes unspoken, however, is how deeply men experience



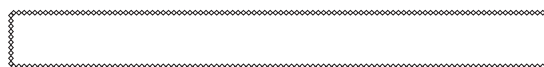
loneliness—a feeling that affects them just as much as it does women. The key difference is that men rarely talk about it or seek out friends to share their struggles. Instead, they internalize their emotions, often suffering in silence.

Societal expectations make it difficult for men to admit they feel lonely, let alone discuss it openly. Men are pressured to project strength and stoicism, as if nothing can penetrate their emotional armor. Yet, beneath this facade, many men grapple with feelings of isolation and yearn for deeper connections—not just with women, but also with other men. In a book I read, the author described emotional intimacy as “the experience of

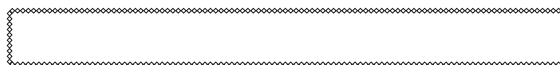


being deeply connected to another person who knows and understands your most important feelings and shares their own with you.” The author also noted that men who struggle with emotional intimacy are more likely to withdraw during times of stress, precisely when they need support the most. This pattern of isolation became evident to me through conversations with a close male friend, who often felt lonely despite his outward appearance of confidence.

Loneliness among men is a widespread issue, cutting across all ages and relationship statuses. Married men, in particular, often feel they have no one to turn to. Many fear their wives won't

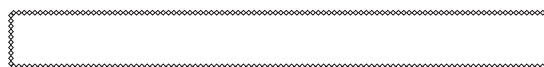


understand their loneliness or offer sympathy, while others assume their male friends aren't interested in hearing about their struggles. Men typically bond over topics like sports, work, politics, or attractive women—not their innermost feelings. Through a survey I conducted with both married and single men, I discovered that married men with children often feel the loneliest. This isn't to say all married fathers are unhappy, but many feel isolated within their marriages. They describe feeling neglected, as if they've fallen to the bottom of their family's priority list. For these men, the shift often begins after the birth of their children, when their wives' attention turns entirely to the kids, the household,



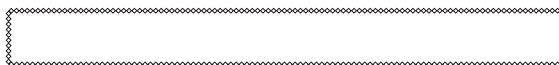
and even the family pet. While men are often willing to prioritize their wives' happiness, they feel their own needs and desires no longer matter.

A significant factor contributing to this loneliness is the decline in physical intimacy. Many men connect emotionally with their partners through sexual affection, and a lack of intimacy can leave them feeling unwanted and isolated. One 54-year-old married friend, a father of two, shared how devastating it was to feel that he no longer attracted his wife. For him, this lack of affection was at the core of his loneliness. Ironically, many of these men still deeply love their wives and couldn't imagine being with anyone



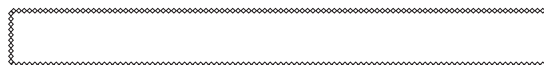
else. However, the absence of intimacy and affection can become unbearable, leading some to consider affairs. Others endure the isolation out of love for their families, unwilling to risk their marriages despite their unhappiness.

This raises an important question: Is simply “pressing on” the best we can hope for? Absolutely not. Hearing so many stories of men who feel they can’t share their true emotions was disheartening. Most of the men I spoke to lacked close male friends they could confide in, and married men often have few platonic female friendships. This leaves many men feeling hopeless and isolated, with no clear outlet for their emotions. While

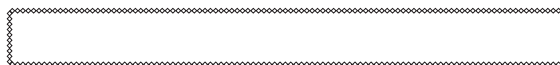


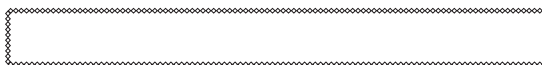
it's becoming more acceptable for men to discuss their feelings openly, we still need to create safe spaces where they can do so without fear of judgment.

If you're a woman reading this, consider showing your husband affection and letting him know he still excites you. Small gestures can go a long way in alleviating his feelings of loneliness. If you're a man who resonates with this, try opening up to your wife about how you feel. Share how much her affection means to you and how much you miss the connection you once had. Honest communication can help bridge the emotional gap and foster a happier, more fulfilling relationship.



Ultimately, loneliness among men is a pervasive issue that deserves attention. By fostering open dialogue and creating supportive environments, we can help men feel less isolated and more connected—both to their partners and to themselves.





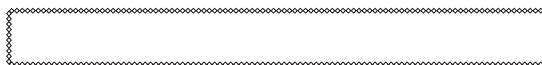


***THE KIND OF
LONELINESS THAT
GIVES A HEART ACHE***





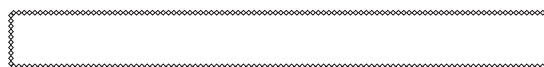
Loneliness is a complex and often misunderstood emotion. While it may seem simple on the surface, its impact can be profound and even life-threatening. For some, loneliness can lead to severe emotional distress, contributing to depression, self-harm, or even suicide. It's a silent struggle that affects people from all walks of life, regardless of their circumstances.



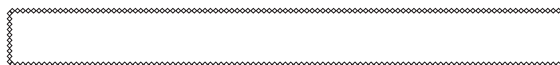
Take, for example, Mrs. Stella Fowoshere, a 45-year-old professional woman from Osun State, Nigeria. On the surface, her life seems ideal—she's happily married with two lovely children and has a successful career. Yet, despite her seemingly perfect life, she experiences a deep sense of loneliness. After moving back to her hometown with her husband to be closer to family, she left behind a close-knit group of female friends she had built over the years. Now, she finds herself longing for the companionship she once had. Seeing groups of women laughing together or enjoying each other's company only amplifies her feelings of isolation. At her age, making new friends feels daunting, as many people already

have established social circles. Her story highlights how loneliness can creep into even the most seemingly fulfilled lives.

Loneliness isn't limited to those who are physically alone. A 33-year-old man with a large circle of friends and acquaintances also struggles with loneliness. As many of his friends marry and start families, he finds himself increasingly isolated. A few years ago, he battled depression, and even now, he feels lonely on weekends. Working in a small office with limited social interaction exacerbates his feelings of disconnection. His story illustrates how loneliness can persist even when surrounded by people, especially as life evolves and relationships change.

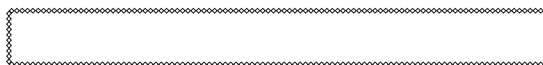


Marriage, often seen as a safeguard against loneliness, can sometimes be its source. A peculiar kind of loneliness arises when you're married to someone who doesn't love or understand you. This isn't the occasional loneliness of missing your spouse during a business trip or the grief of losing a partner. It's a constant, gnawing loneliness that permeates every moment. It's the loneliness of sharing your deepest feelings only to have them dismissed or ridiculed. It's the loneliness of craving physical affection and emotional connection but receiving none. For some, the only cure for this type of loneliness is to leave the relationship and rediscover themselves. As Hazel Katherine Larkin poignantly writes, this



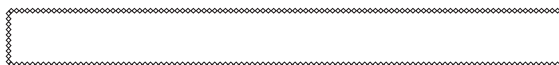
loneliness can choke the life out of you, leaving you longing for the person you once were.

Loneliness can also stem from internal struggles, as in the case of a young man who, despite being bubbly and outgoing, battled paranoia and insecurity. He often doubted his worth and withdrew from social circles, convinced that his absence wouldn't be noticed. His lowest point came during a weekend trip with friends, where he chose to sleep outside rather than ask for help when locked out of his accommodation. A friend's kindness that night—offering him a place to sleep—was a turning point. Through mindfulness and self-reflection, he learned to manage



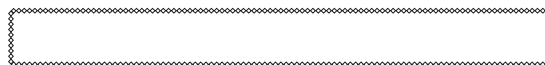
his fears and embrace the value of his relationships.

Loneliness can strike unexpectedly, even in the midst of a busy, fulfilling life. A woman in her forties with a loving husband, five children, and a close-knit family still feels the sting of loneliness since her father's death six years ago. Small reminders of him—a stranger's walk, an old man fumbling for his wallet—trigger waves of grief and isolation. She describes loneliness as a “dark grey, slimy colour,” a gut-wrenching feeling that can hit at any moment. Her story reminds us that loneliness isn't always about being alone; it's about feeling unseen and unheard, even in a crowd.



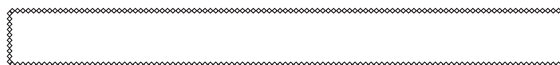
For a young single mother, loneliness was a constant companion. With two young children, she was never physically alone but felt desperately lonely every day. As her peers pursued travel and education, she focused on raising her boys, often neglecting her own needs. Starting a blog provided a creative outlet and a sense of community, transforming her life and improving her mental health. Her story underscores the importance of finding connection and support, even in the most challenging circumstances.

Loneliness also affects marginalized communities, such as LGBTQ+ individuals. A 29-year-old man campaigning for marriage equality in Ireland reflects on

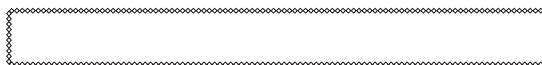


his teenage years, marked by fear and isolation. At 17, he was warned to hide his sexuality, and at 18, he contemplated suicide. While progress has been made, he hopes that today's gay teens feel less alone. His story highlights the ongoing need for acceptance and understanding to combat the loneliness faced by marginalized groups.

In Africa, discussing topics like loneliness or LGBTQ+ identity remains taboo. Many suffer in silence, unable to share their experiences due to societal stigma. Loneliness, in all its forms, is a universal human experience, but it's one we must address with compassion and openness. By listening to one another and offering



support, we can alleviate the pain of loneliness and create a more connected world.





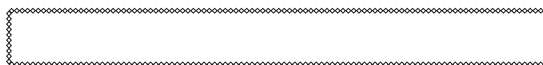
SURVIVING THE TRANSITION TO ADULTHOOD





Preparing for Adulthood

Growing up is a journey that everyone experiences at their own pace. While society and laws recognize us as adults at 18, the transition to adulthood can be challenging for both teenagers and their parents. Change is difficult, but planning ahead can make it easier. This guide is designed to help you prepare for life after 18 by outlining key areas to consider, identifying tasks you can handle

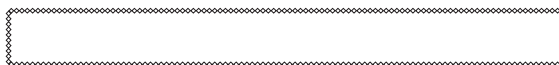


independently, and determining when to seek help from others—such as parents, guardians, doctors, schools, or legal aid. Start planning at least a year before turning 18 to ensure a smooth transition.

The guide is divided into 10 parts, each addressing essential aspects of adulthood. For each topic, assess whether action is needed and identify who can assist you. Let's look into these areas in detail.

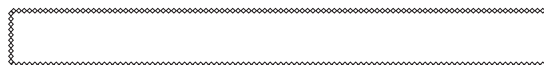
1. Navigating the Digital World

In today's world, access to computers and the internet is crucial. Computers are valuable tools for finding information, applying for jobs, managing budgets, and



developing skills for future employment. If you don't own a computer, you can access one at libraries, schools, or community centers. Many friends or family members may also have computers you can use.

If you're unfamiliar with computers, seek help from librarians, teachers, or community center counselors. Start by learning basic skills, such as using search engines like Google to find information. The internet offers endless resources, from job listings to educational materials. Don't hesitate to ask for assistance—libraries and schools are excellent places to begin your journey into the digital world.



2. Lifelong Learning

Education is a cornerstone of success. Whether you're in special education (which can extend to age 21) or regular education, finishing school is vital. A high school diploma opens doors to better-paying jobs, college, vocational training, or military service.

If you're considering college, start researching and applying during your junior year of high school. For those interested in trades, look for part-time jobs, summer work, or high school courses that provide hands-on experience. Talk to people in your desired field to learn more about their careers. Planning ahead ensures you gain the skills and

qualifications needed to achieve your goals.

3. Finding Employment

Securing a job that provides a livable income is a key step toward independence. Start by identifying your skills and the skills required for your desired job. A high school diploma is often the minimum requirement for many positions. Research job opportunities and understand any prerequisites, such as background checks or specific training.

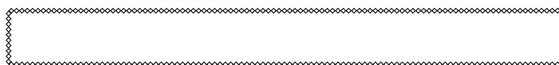
Seek guidance from career counselors, teachers, or online resources to explore job options. Networking with professionals in your field of interest can also provide

valuable insights. Remember, preparation and persistence are key to finding a job that meets your financial needs.

4. Healthcare and Support

Healthcare is a critical aspect of adult life. Ensure you have health insurance to cover medical expenses, as treatment costs can be overwhelming. If you're covered under your parents' private insurance, confirm how long this coverage lasts—often until age 25 if you're in school. Medicaid and disability insurance typically end at 18, so reapply for these benefits if needed.

If you have a mental health condition, physical disability, or substance abuse disorder, transition to adult services

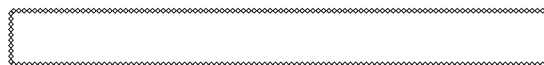


before turning 18. Work with your doctor or counselor to create a plan for ongoing care. For those with disabilities that affect decision-making, consider whether guardianship arrangements are necessary.

If you have children, explore programs that support their healthcare needs. Public health clinics and social service agencies can provide assistance, including help with child support.

5. Housing Options

Deciding where to live after turning 18 is a significant decision. Many choose to stay with family, while others move out on their own. Living independently can

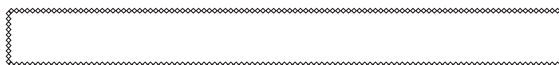


be expensive, so consider costs like rent, utilities, and transportation.

If you plan to live with family, discuss responsibilities such as paying rent, contributing to groceries, and adhering to household rules. Demonstrating responsibility can prepare you for future independence. For those needing immediate housing, local shelters can provide temporary accommodations and help you find permanent housing.

6. Transportation

Reliable transportation is essential for work, school, and appointments. Whether you use public transit, drive a car, or carpool, plan your routes and schedules



in advance. If you're considering buying a car, factor in costs like insurance and maintenance.

For public transportation, familiarize yourself with bus schedules and routes. If driving isn't an option, explore carpooling with coworkers or neighbors. Being punctual and reliable is crucial, especially for work commitments.

7. Daily Living Skills

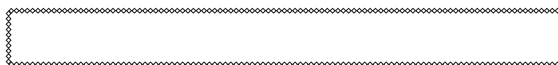
Living independently requires mastering basic life skills, such as cooking, cleaning, laundry, budgeting, and home maintenance. Many of these skills are taught by family or learned through experience. If you're unsure, seek

guidance from programs, schools, or trusted adults.

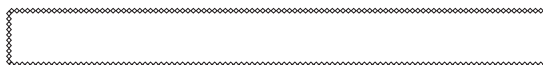
Eating out frequently can be costly, so learning to prepare meals and shop for groceries is essential. Keeping your living space clean and organized also contributes to your overall well-being. Practice these skills before moving out to ensure you're prepared for the responsibilities of independent living.

8. Building a Support Network

Social connections are vital for mental and emotional health. Engage in activities that interest you, such as sports, art, music, or volunteering. These activities can help you meet like-minded individuals and build a supportive community.



Consider joining clubs, groups, or organizations that align with your interests. Even at work, you may find opportunities to connect with others. Building a strong support network can provide encouragement and companionship as you navigate adulthood.



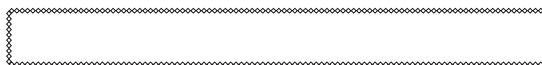


CONCLUSION





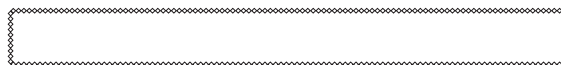
Loneliness is a complex and often distressing emotional response to isolation, characterized by feelings of disconnection and a lack of meaningful communication with others. It can be experienced even in the presence of other people, highlighting that loneliness is deeply personal and subjective. Its causes are multifaceted, stemming from social, mental, emotional, and

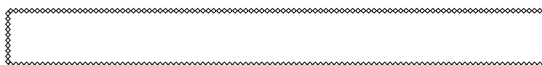


physical factors. Research reveals that loneliness is widespread, affecting individuals across all walks of life—married couples, families, veterans, and even those with successful careers. It has been a recurring theme in human literature since Classical antiquity, often described as a form of “social pain” that motivates individuals to seek meaningful connections. Loneliness is commonly defined as the unpleasant experience that arises when a person’s social relationships are lacking in significant ways. Studies have explored various interventions to address loneliness, including improving social skills, enhancing social support, increasing

opportunities for interaction, and addressing maladaptive social cognition (faulty thought patterns). Among these, correcting maladaptive social cognition has shown the most promise in effectively reducing loneliness. While all interventions have demonstrated some success, social skill training appears to be the least effective. Loneliness is a universal yet deeply personal experience that requires targeted interventions to address its root causes. Fostering healthier social cognition and creating opportunities for meaningful connections can help individuals and societies work toward alleviating the

burden of loneliness and promoting emotional well-being.





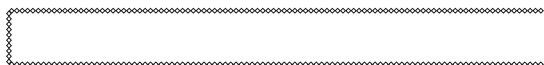


APPRECIATION

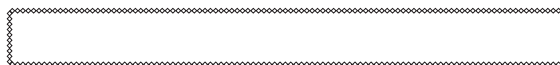




You are deeply honoured and appreciated for the unwavering support and guidance you have provided us. Your dedication, time, and genuine interest in our growth have made a profound impact. Like the sunrise that brings light to those in darkness, your presence has illuminated our lives, showing us the value of your contributions. We treasure and appreciate you



immensely, knowing how much we have grown since you came into our lives. Thank you for everything.



The book narrates the story and experience of the author and other people that had similar encounters and thrived through. Different experience for different people under divers conditions as the book depicts. There is always a root cause to every problems, and proffering solutions to those problems would need a thorough knowledge of the causative agents which the book really expanciates up on. To thrive while living alone, focuses on self-care, building meaningful connections, establishing routines, and embracing the freedom and opportunities for personal growth that comes with independence. This book would take you through every necessities to survive under divers conditions.



Gabriel M. Gishmaf is an accomplished Mechanical Engineer, tech entrepreneur, and multi-talented creative. Born in the late 1980s in Lagos, Nigeria, he is the last of seven children and overcame early life struggles to excel academically.

He specialized in fluid mechanics at the University of Benin and later earned multiple professional certifications in safety, system security, and software development.

Beyond engineering, Gabriel is a skilled programmer, proficient in Java, Python, Django, and more. He is also an avid musician, mastering instruments such as the saxophone, violin, piano, and guitar. With international work experience in robotics, logistics, and IT, he founded Gishmaf Global Company in 2021, providing innovative tech solutions and consultancy services.

A passionate storyteller, Gabriel draws inspiration from real-life experiences, resilience, and personal growth. In 2024, he successfully launched his debut book, *Escape from the Street*, sharing a compelling journey of survival and transformation.